Third System
AI Presence Index

One Score or Two?

We tested every pre-set way of folding Consistency into Presence. None added anything, so the AI Availability Score now reports two numbers.

November 2026 · Pablo Ulpiano González Castro

AIAS™ Measurement Program

Third System™ now measures two things about a brand in AI answers: Presence, how often AI models name it, and Consistency, whether the models agree about it. The obvious next step was one combined AIAS™ number. Before building it, we fixed the tests a combined number would have to pass, ran them on the May and June data, and then checked the outcome blind on November's. No combined number passed. Brand teams get two scores, each reliable over five months, and each saying something the other does not.

All eight pre-specified ways of combining the two scores failed at least one of three tests. Each that kept Consistency separate ranked brands almost exactly as Presence already does. Shown side by side, the two scores held their brand order from June to November (0.95 and 0.65) and stayed unrelated (0.19).

Three findings and one rule. First, no combined score passed: each candidate either pulled Consistency toward Presence, gave brands credit for a mention or two, or ranked brands as Presence already does. Second, the reason is a difference in spread: Presence runs across the whole scale, while Consistency, for the brands it can rate, sits high, so any average follows Presence. Third, the two scores work as a pair: tested blind on November's data, both kept their brand order and stayed separate. The rule: Consistency is rated only for brands named at least six times across the six models; below that, agreement cannot be observed.

The implication for brand teams: read the two numbers separately. Presence says how often AI names you. Consistency says whether that visibility is shared across models or depends on a few of them. A combined score would hide the second answer inside the first.

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What we measured

The data are the five categories the program has tracked since May 2026: audiophile headphones, skincare, cosmetics, automotive and premium spirits, 112 brands asked about in the same words by the same six models (two each from Anthropic, OpenAI and Google), in May, June and November.

Before looking at any result we fixed eight candidate combined scores: two ways to score Consistency, two ways to handle brands with few mentions, and two ways to combine. Each had to pass three tests in both May and June. Consistency must stay separate from Presence; the combined score must rank brands differently from Presence; and a brand named once or twice must not gain more than Presence already gives it. The selection rule, including what to do if nothing passed, was written down before the tests ran. The outcome was then registered publicly and checked on the November wave, which had not been collected yet.

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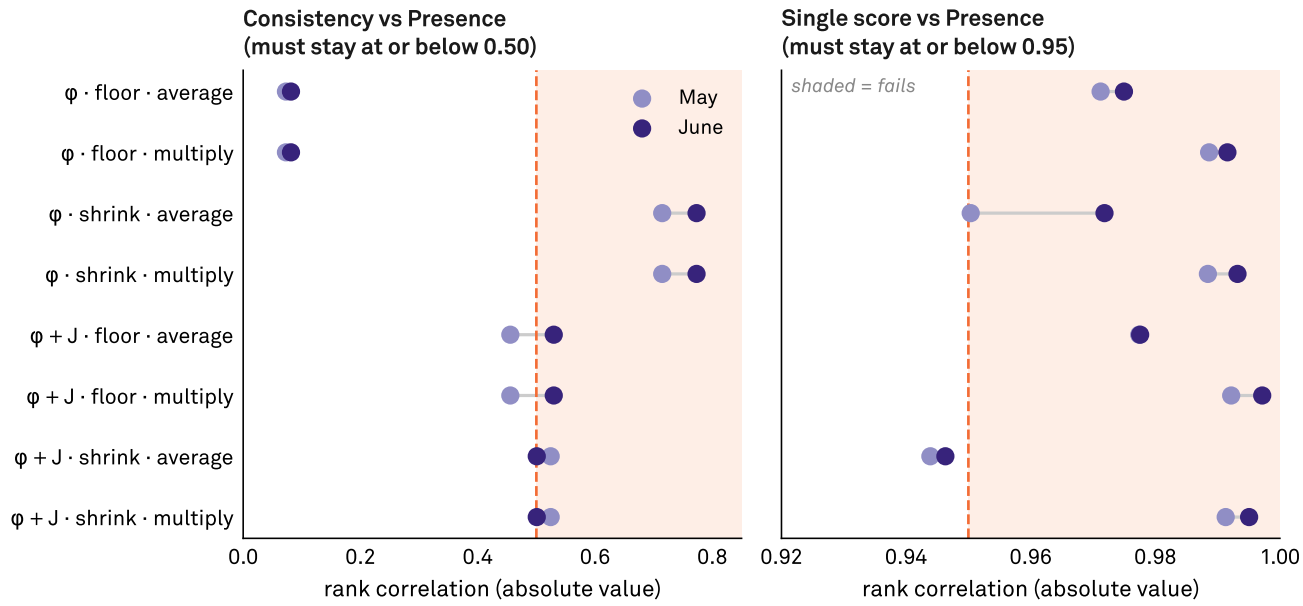
FINDING 01

No single score passed

No single score passed

The eight pre-specified ways to combine the two scores, tested on the May and June waves.

Each row: Consistency score · rule for brands with few mentions · how the two scores are combined.



P1 NOT SUPPORTED: no combined score passed all three tests; every candidate failed at least one.

Source: AIAS™ v1.9 (Two-Component Composite Calibration) | Protocol v1.9-prereg-r1 | Third System™

The eight pre-specified ways of combining Presence and Consistency into one score, each tested on the May and June waves. Left: whether the Consistency score stays separate from Presence. Right: whether the combined score carries anything Presence does not. Every candidate lands in a shaded zone on at least one side.

The eight candidates combine two Consistency scores (dispersion alone, or dispersion with a positional measure), two rules for brands with few mentions (leave them unrated, or pull their score toward the middle) and two ways to combine (average, or multiply). Every one failed at least one test, so under the rule written in advance, no combined score is adopted.

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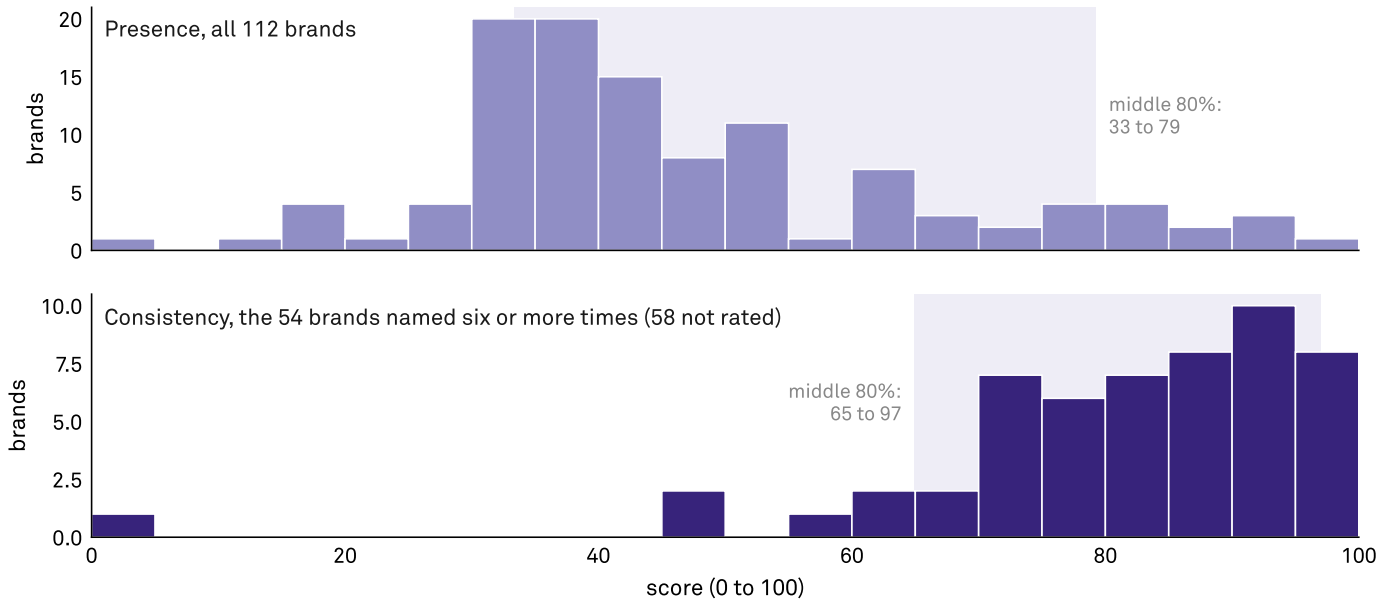
FINDING 02

One number would repeat Presence

Why one number repeats Presence

Distribution of each score across the five categories, November 2026.

Averaging a score that spreads wide with one that sits high ranks brands by the wide one.



P2 SUPPORTED: Presence spreads across the whole scale while rated Consistency sits high, so an average follows Presence.

Source: AIAS™ v1.9 (Two-Component Composite Calibration) | Protocol v1.9-prereg-r1 | Third System™

Presence and Consistency across all 112 brands in November. Presence runs from near zero to near 100; Consistency, for the 54 brands named often enough to rate, mostly sits between 65 and 97. An equal-weight average is therefore ranked almost entirely by Presence.

The candidates that kept Consistency separate from Presence produced a combined score that ranked brands at 0.97 to 0.99 with Presence alone, against a limit of 0.95. The reason is spread: Presence runs from near zero to near 100, while rated Consistency sits mostly between 65 and 97. In November the best candidate still matched Presence at 0.97.

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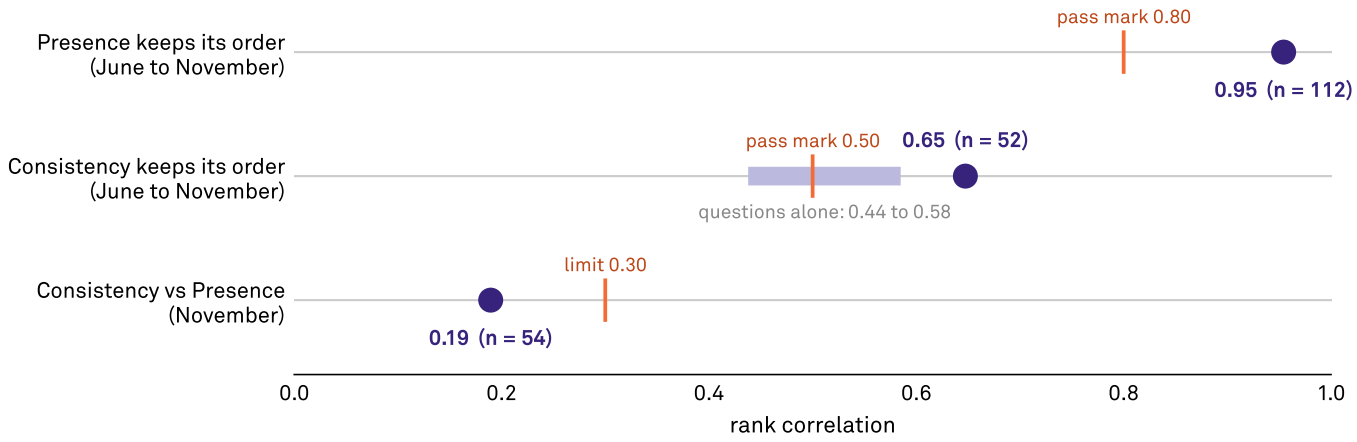
FINDING 03

Two reliable scores, kept apart

Two reliable scores, kept apart

Blind check on the November wave, under the rules fixed before it was collected.

Shaded band: how stable Consistency looks from the structure of the questions alone (average to 95th percentile).



P3 SUPPORTED: both reported scores held their order over five months and stayed separate (tested blind).

Source: AIAS™ v1.9 (Two-Component Composite Calibration) | Protocol v1.9-prereg-r1 | Third System™

The blind check on November's data, scored under rules fixed before that data existed. Both reported scores kept their brand order from June, Consistency by more than the question structure alone produces, and the two stayed unrelated.

June to November, Presence kept its brand order at 0.95 across all 112 brands. Consistency kept its order at 0.65 across the 52 brands rated in both waves; scrambling which model gave which answer would produce 0.44 on average and 0.58 at most in 95 of 100 tries, so the score is more stable than the questions alone explain. In November the two scores were related at only 0.19 (54 brands), within the limit of 0.30.

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FINDING 04

Consistency needs at least six mentions

A brand named once or twice looks consistent by default: its Consistency score averaged 85 in the early data, higher than for brands named 19 times or more (76). Pulling such scores toward the middle tied Consistency to Presence (0.72 to 0.77). Leaving them unrated kept the two separate and made Consistency more reliable over three weeks (0.74 against 0.53). The cost is coverage: 51 to 52% of brands are not rated in each wave.

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Two scores, side by side

Presence answers how often AI names a brand; Consistency answers whether the models agree. Reported side by side, a brand can see that it is often named but only by some models, or rarely named but consistently so. A brand too rarely named to rate is shown as not rated, not as inconsistent.

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Limitations

The May and June data had been analysed before, so that stage is calibration, not a test; only the November check is a test. Eight candidates is a deliberately small, pre-set list; other forms of combined score were not tried, so the result says none of these adds information, not that none ever could.

Everything here applies to one panel of six models, now retiring, which answer without web search; a new panel needs its own calibration. Five categories and 112 brands limit the precision of every figure, and the November Consistency checks rest on about 50 brands. Neither score has yet been tested against what buyers actually do.

What’s next

The program's next synthesis reports Presence and Consistency side by side under these definitions, with the share of brands too rarely named to rate shown next to Consistency.

The same tests will be run on the current generation of models, with web search off and on, before their scores are compared with these. The question of one combined number reopens when a third component is measured, under the same tests and the same rule.

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The five propositions, scored

Each proposition is the managerial reading of a locked result, scored for brand teams rather than reviewers.

#	Proposition	Status
P1	A combined Presence and Consistency score passes all three tests.	*NOT SUPPORTED — 8 of 8 candidates failed at least one test; the rule fixed in advance therefore locks two scores*
P2	A combined score ranks brands as Presence already does.	**SUPPORTED — 0.97 to 0.99 with Presence in May and June; 0.97 again in November**
P3	Both reported scores hold their order and stay separate over five months.	**SUPPORTED — tested blind: 0.95 and 0.65 June to November; 0.19 between them**
P4	Consistency is rated only for brands named six or more times.	*LOCKED RULE — fixed before the November check; about half the brands are not rated*
P5	The AI Availability Score reports Presence and Consistency separately.	*DECIDED — follows from P1 to P3 under the rule set in advance*

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A score earns its place by telling you something you did not already know. Tested against rules set in advance, a single AI Availability number did not: it repeated Presence. Two numbers do, and both held for five months. Until a further component changes that, the honest report is the pair.

About the Third System

The Third System describes a shift in how consumers make decisions: instead of browsing and comparing options directly, many now rely on AI systems to generate recommendations. In this environment, brands compete not only for human attention but for inclusion within AI-generated outputs. This creates a new competitive layer where visibility is determined by how AI systems interpret and surface brands.

Authored by

Pablo Ulpiano González Castro

School of Visual Arts, MPS Branding Program, New York, NY

Third System™ (research entity)

Methodology

This report presents findings from Third System's AI Availability research program. The AI Availability Score (AIAS) is an early-stage measurement framework introduced in Tri-System Brand Growth (Gonzalez Castro, 2026). Findings should be used directionally. Construct validity — the correlation between AI Availability and consumer behavior — has not yet been established and is the subject of Phase 3 of the research program. Methodology is published in full and versioned at thirdsystem.ai/methodology (current: v1.8). Registry construction is curated and reflects the framework's view of each category's competitive set; revisions are documented in the methodology log.

Citation

González Castro, P. U. (2026). ***One Score or Two? Calibrating a Presence and Consistency Composite for AI Brand Availability (AIAS Methodology v1.9)***. Third System (SSRN pending). thirdsystem.ai/methodology

Underlying datasets

Stage 2 verdicts: osf.io/ec6wh/methodology/v1_9/v1_9_verdicts.json

Stage 1 calibration: osf.io/ec6wh/methodology/v1_9/prereg/v1_9_calibration.json

Scoring code: osf.io/ec6wh/methodology/v1_9/scripts/score_v1_9.py

Pre-registration: osf.io/ec6wh/methodology/v1_9/prereg/ (tag v1.9-prereg-r1)

Methodology log: v1.9 (SSRN pending).

Inquiries: hello@thirdsystem.ai